

## *Ukraine: Elections before a ceasefire remain unlikely*

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Elections before a ceasefire remain unlikely despite mounting pressure on Zelensky|||||||

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### What Happened

Mykhailo Fedorov, the recently dismissed defense minister, has released a video calling for Ukraine to hold elections. Separately, the National Anti-Corruption Bureau of Ukraine presented new corruption allegations against figures in President Volodymyr Zelensky's inner circle, including his deputy head of office, whom the president promptly dismissed.

### Our Take

Fedorov's call for elections positions him as a potential opposition leader. He is the first prominent figure to openly call for elections, in a direct challenge to Zelensky. Polling by the Kyiv International Institute of Sociology (KIIS) gives Fedorov the strongest net rating among leading political figures, with 63% trust and 16% distrust, ahead of former commander-in-chief Valery Zaluzhnyi, at 66% trust and 24% distrust, and well ahead of Zelensky, at 56% trust and 38% distrust.

If Fedorov's popularity endures and his message gains traction within the military and the bureaucracy, Ukraine could enter a new phase of wartime politics. Zelensky would then have to manage not only the demands of governing under fire but also active competition from a credible rival operating outside the wartime consensus.

However, Fedorov could still fade into the background. Not only do other popular figures, including Kyrylo Budanov and Mykhailo Drapatyi, back Zelensky, but the coming winter will once again consolidate the public around the priority of survival.

Regardless of whether his support lasts, Fedorov's call broadens the range of what Ukraine's political class may now treat as acceptable wartime campaigning.

Elections before a ceasefire remain unlikely. Discussions this spring about a wartime vote stemmed mainly from US pressure, but plans for a voting mechanism under martial law stalled over unresolved security and logistical obstacles. Organizing safe, fair, and legitimate elections with international observers will probably take several months after a ceasefire, which is unlikely this year

Moreover, most voters and politicians still see an early election as destabilizing and beneficial only to Russia. KIIS polling shows that just 15% support elections before the fighting ends, 23% back a vote after a ceasefire, and 57% prefer to wait for a final peace agreement. The legal challenges are also substantial. Parliament would first have to lift martial law, and Zelensky's party retains enough votes to block such a move while the opposition remains divided.

The new corruption allegations will narrow Zelensky's room to govern. The wartime consensus that once gave the president broad latitude is eroding, as highlighted by the public protests triggered by his decision to remove Fedorov.

The greatest risk to Zelensky's position is a new corruption scandal combined with an increasingly forceful opposition able to channel public frustration into demands for a coalition government or other concessions.

Otherwise, the likelier effect of Zelensky's declining popularity will be a reduced capacity to pass legislation and govern without public challenge.

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